

scholarships he got standard after standard, starting Class V. In 10th standard, he was at 9th rank in the merit list of the entire UP Board of Education. The feat was repeated in 1982 when he secured 6th rank in UP State merit list for 12th standard.

"I had only one sweater to wear in winters, and it was clear in my mind that going out to play would mean getting it dirty and going to school without wearing one. There was no choice other than staying back home most winter days," he recalls! And while staying at home most of the time would sound like a major setback to a lot of children; to him, it was an opportunity to read more!

He smiles and adds, "I think that one sweater is what made me read more. One sweater is what made it possible for me to stand in the top 10 list of students for standard 10 exams. That sweater made me a hero amongst a million students!"

Phoolpati Devi, Srivastava's mother and his first role model, meanwhile continued to teach her children the importance of studying and working hard. Srivastava remembers incidents when she would skip meals because one of her children needed a new notebook! Meanwhile, his eldest brother had cleared his engineering and got a job. This also meant that the eldest brother was now supporting the whole family, and this is when he became the second role model for Srivastava!

"Family is the most important thing in the universe" is what I learnt from my eldest brother. He was the first graduate engineer from our village, and that made us all immensely proud, Srivastava recalls. Eating puri-sabji is one of the most cherished memories of Srivastava from his childhood days. He remembers how his mother would cook puri-sabji even at 10 pm in the night because he wanted to enjoy the same. In his mother's words conveyed by Sriv-

astava to us, "The most important priority in life should be hard work; rest everything falls in place." She used to tell her kids these lines when they had to choose between meals and buying a book!

The ₹750 difference in BHU and IIT Roorkee

Having done much of his schooling via the 100% scholarship route, Srivastava did not just master academics but also understood the value of punctuality and discipline, and never took the scholarships offered by the government for granted. Apart from his dedication towards education, he credits his mother for the same.

"I hardly took leave from school. Even on days when it poured, I went to school. My mother would ensure that I go to school on days it rained for checking whether a holiday was announced or not! On most such days, I was among a few students who showed up to school," he recalls.

Though the financial condition that the family had to go through after the death of his father had taught him about the value of money, the same proved to be one of the crucial deciding factors when it came to choosing between IIT and BHU! Pursuing engineering was Srivastava's first choice, but everyone told him that his chances were bleak as the IIT entrance exam was conducted in English.

"Though I studied in Hindi medium, I was a topper in English subject throughout school. With excellent academic results with rank in state merit, I was confident that I will be able to crack the IIT entrance," he shares.

And so, he did! However, he got 1110 rank in the IIT entrance. At the same time, he also gave exams for the University of Roorkee, a very prestigious institute (presently IIT Roorkee), where the option to answer in Hindi was also available. In this exam, he secured a rank in



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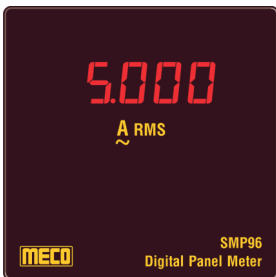


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